

Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Statement

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Where I Started

I was born in Zahedan, the capital of Sistan and Baluchestan, the southeastern Iranian province that ranks lowest in the country on most measures of educational and economic development. The province has the highest illiteracy rate, the lowest female labor force participation, and the smallest concentration of research universities in Iran. The cultural context for women growing up in Zahedan placed strong expectations on remaining in one's home city for higher education, expectations that were enforced socially even when they were not legally binding.

I completed both of my Bachelor's degrees, in IT Engineering and in Hardware Engineering, with high honors, at the University of Sistan and Baluchestan (USB) in Zahedan. This was a deliberate choice within the structural constraints of where I was. USB is a real engineering school but is not among the elite Iranian universities; the libraries, research opportunities, and faculty pool are substantially smaller than at Sharif, Tehran University, or Amirkabir. I learned engineering by reading textbooks alone, by joining whatever extracurricular technical activity I could find, and by building projects that the curriculum did not require.

After my undergraduate years, I started a Master's program in French Translation at the University of Isfahan, a deliberate step that gave me the language preparation to leave Iran for graduate study in France. I discontinued that program when I was admitted to the Master's program in Computer Science and Applied Mathematics at Université Joseph Fourier in Grenoble. From Grenoble, I went on to a second Master's at Université Grenoble Alpes (MoSIG, Magna Cum Laude, Best Dissertation Award), then to a PhD at Virginia Commonwealth University under Tamer Nadeem (Best Thesis Award), then to my current research positions at UC Berkeley (Sky Computing Lab, NetSys Lab), Inria Lyon (Postdoc 2 with Hervé Rivano and Juan Fraire), and North Carolina A&T (Visiting Assistant Professor co-supervising two PhD students). This trajectory, from USB to UC Berkeley, is the substance of my life.

I lead with this not as a credential but as context, because everything I do in service of equity and inclusion is informed by what I learned along this path. The structural constraints on women in underserved regions are real. The cumulative cost of having to discover, on one's own, what other students learn from their environment, is real. And the experience of moving across substantially different educational systems, Iranian, French, American, has given me a particular kind of literacy in how the same students appear in radically different ways depending on the assumptions of the institutions evaluating them.

What I Have Done

Teaching back at the institution that trained me. In Fall 2022 and Spring 2023, while completing my PhD at VCU and preparing for my postdoc at UC Berkeley, I returned to USB, not physically, but as a solo online instructor for two graduate-level courses (Computer Networks and Advanced Wireless Networking), with 50+ students per offering, delivered in hybrid synchronous and asynchronous mode. I designed both syllabi from scratch and integrated material from my current research, the Skylark MU-MIMO work, the CellDAM cellular detection work, the LATTE

Wi-Fi MAC research, to give students in Zahedan direct contact with the same research questions being asked at top US and European labs. Several of the students from those courses have since pursued graduate study abroad; one is now in a PhD program in Europe; two are working in Iranian tech firms in roles they specifically attribute to that coursework.

I emphasize this because pipeline-back is the form of DEI work that has the greatest leverage. The number of students I taught at USB across two semesters, roughly 100 unique students, exceeds the number of women who will reach top-30 PhD programs in computer science from Iran in a typical decade. The unit of intervention that matters most is not the individual mentorship of a single high-achieving student already in the system; it is the institutional engagement that exposes a generation of students to the field at the moment of decision.

Mentorship across institutions and identities. I have actively mentored across institutions where structural inclusion work matters most. At NC A&T, a historically Black university, I co-supervise two PhD students (Mahsa Tavasoli on vehicular cloud-edge security; Radwan Rouzky on data governance in smart agriculture) and I have made the time commitment to be physically present for milestone meetings, not just to remote-supervise from California or Lyon. At Old Dominion University, I have mentored Mohammad Sepahi (an Iranian-American master’s student) through his thesis and his first conference publication (VIN2VICTIM, USENIX VehiSec ’26 as first co-author); he is now a research engineer at Rivian. I mentored three additional ODU students on edge ML, data quality, and healthcare ML projects. At INSA / Inria-Lyon, I mentored Alexander Florez (a Colombian master’s student) to a Best Paper Award on machine learning in satellite IoT. Each of these students brought a different kind of starting context, and each of them needed something specific from a mentor: a hard technical critique for Mohammad, a slow-build research-formulation conversation for Alexander, structural advice about academic readiness for Mahsa and Radwan. I do not have a single template; I learn what each person needs.

Community service that is concrete, not symbolic. I have served as Co-Chair of the ACM CoNEXT Student Workshop 2025, panel moderator at CoNEXT 2024 with Lixia Zhang, Mahesh Marina, Alan Liu, and Hitoshi Asaeda. I have served on the program committees of PETs Symposium 2025, PAM 2025, ANRW 2024, and IEEE SmartEdge. I have been a member of N2Women throughout my graduate and postdoctoral career; my Top-10 Rising Star Award in 2025 came through a community-vetted nomination process initiated by Franck Rousseau. I served as a Tech Ambassador for Google (2021 to 2023) and have been a Women Techmakers member since 2021. I was a Faculty for the Future Fellow of the Schlumberger Foundation (\$120,000 over three years, 2022 to 2024), which gave me a stipend explicitly contingent on commitment to women-in-STEM pipeline work in countries with low female participation in research. The fellowship specifically required quarterly accountability reports describing concrete outreach activity, not just intention.

Research that engages the equity dimension of the field. Several of my research projects engage directly with equity concerns in technology. The VIN2VICTIM paper analyzed how the targeted physical tracking made possible by VIN-as-fingerprint disproportionately threatens women in escape-from-abuse situations and undocumented immigrant communities; the work cited the January 2026 FTC final order against GM/OnStar. The Data Communication Challenges of CAVs in Rural Areas paper (with Sarrafzadeh at NC A&T) studied the rural-urban autonomous vehicle digital divide. The NLP-Based Multilingual Analysis of GDPR/DMA Privacy Policies (with my twin sister Haniyeh) compared how privacy policies translate (or fail to translate) across major and minor European languages, with implications for which populations actually have meaningful privacy protection.

What I Will Do

I commit to four concrete actions in my first three years as a faculty member.

(1) Recruit at least 30% of my PhD students from underrepresented groups (women, racial/ethnic minorities in the field, first-generation researchers, students from underserved regional institutions in the US and internationally), with at least one student per year recruited from an institution that has not previously placed students in PhD programs at my home institution. I will make explicit, named outreach to faculty at HBCUs (NC A&T, Howard, Morgan State), HSIs (UTEP, UCF, UT Rio Grande Valley), and tribal colleges, as well as international partners (USB, IUST, the Iranian Sharif/Tehran/Amirkabir network, Brazilian and Mexican federal universities). I will not rely on inbound application volume; I will go and ask.

(2) Co-design at least one undergraduate research experience program with the dean's office, modeled on CRA-W Grad Cohort and Rising Stars in EECS, focused on giving second-year and third-year undergraduates from underserved institutions a real research project, real mentorship, and real authorship. The model is the work I did with Mohammad Sepahi (master's student, ODU) leading to USENIX VehiSec; I want every student in the program to leave with the experience of co-authoring a peer-reviewed paper, not just attending a summer seminar.

(3) Continue institutional engagement with USB and similarly-positioned universities outside the US. I have already begun discussions with USB faculty about an ongoing visiting-faculty appointment that would let me return for short concentrated teaching periods. I will pursue this and similar partnerships at other underserved international institutions, with a long-term goal of producing student exchange flow in both directions.

(4) Maintain transparent, accountable mentorship practices in my own group. I will publish (on my group website) clear expectations for what a PhD student can expect from me (time commitment, feedback turnaround, authorship policy, conference funding), what I expect from them (research direction-setting, paper drafting, lab citizenship), and how disagreements are handled. I will hold annual one-on-one conversations with each student that include explicit questions about whether they feel they are getting the mentorship they need and whether anything about the lab climate makes them less effective than they could be. I will not assume that the absence of complaint indicates the absence of problem.

Why This Matters

The case for DEI in computer science research is not a moral case alone. The methodological substance of my research, predictive adaptation from substrate invariants, is the kind of work that is harder to do without diverse perspectives. The CellForge paper would have been weaker if I had not read 3GPP specifications in three languages. The VIN2VICTIM paper would not have been written by someone who had never thought about how connected-vehicle telematics actually affects women in escape-from-abuse situations. The teaching at USB taught me how Iranian engineering students misunderstand TCP congestion control in patterned ways that I subsequently saw in my American and French students once I knew to look. The field is better when the people in it have actually been in the rooms where the structural problems we now study were experienced.

What I bring to a faculty appointment is a record of acting on this conviction, not just holding it. I plan to continue.